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Dartmouth head aims to usher in era of AI

Policy defies many in higher ed, even at her own school

By Michaela Towfighi
GLOBE STAFF

HANOVER, N.H. — Among a fresh class of female faces at the helm of the Ivy League, Dartmouth College president Sian Leah Beilock is the last woman standing.

At the hands of both protesters and politicians, the newly appointed presidents of the University of Pennsylvania, Harvard University, and Columbia University fell in rapid succession under President Trump's intense pressure campaign against campuses he deemed too left-leaning.

"I came into Dartmouth with several women leaders in the Ivy League who are now not president," she said in an interview with the Globe. "I've been, you could say, in a high-pressure moment for a long time."

After years of keeping her head down — and her signature off of letters of protest — Beilock has put herself squarely in a new high-pressure moment, and in front of a political freight train that is barreling through American society and her own campus as well: artificial intelligence.

She is unapologetic about it.

DARTMOUTH, Page A15

For certain clientele, the $400 haircut fits the bill

Costs drive up price, but many willing to pay

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

It's around noon on a recent weekday, and the upscale salons lining Newbury Street are booked solid. Rows of women in styling chairs, their heads covered in shiny foil packets, scroll their phones. Stylists snip neat layers. Freshly coiffed clients smile at their reflection.

Customers leave with sleek locks and boosted confidence. The bill for their great hair day? Hundreds of dollars. Plus tip.

At high-end salons in Boston and surrounding suburbs, it's no longer unusual for a cut and color to cost $400, $500, or more. While such prices were once reserved for the well-to-do, they've become routine at a growing number of salons, as the cost of doing business — from rent to product to wages — soars.

This isn't 2007, when a $400 haircut tarred a presidential candidate as out of touch with the American people. In an era when a new iPhone retails for $1,200 and a latte goes for $7 or more, salon owners have found many clients are willing to pay.

HAIR, Page A15

Since the pandemic, missed days have ballooned by nearly a third. That means Massachusetts students have missed an extra

15 million school days.

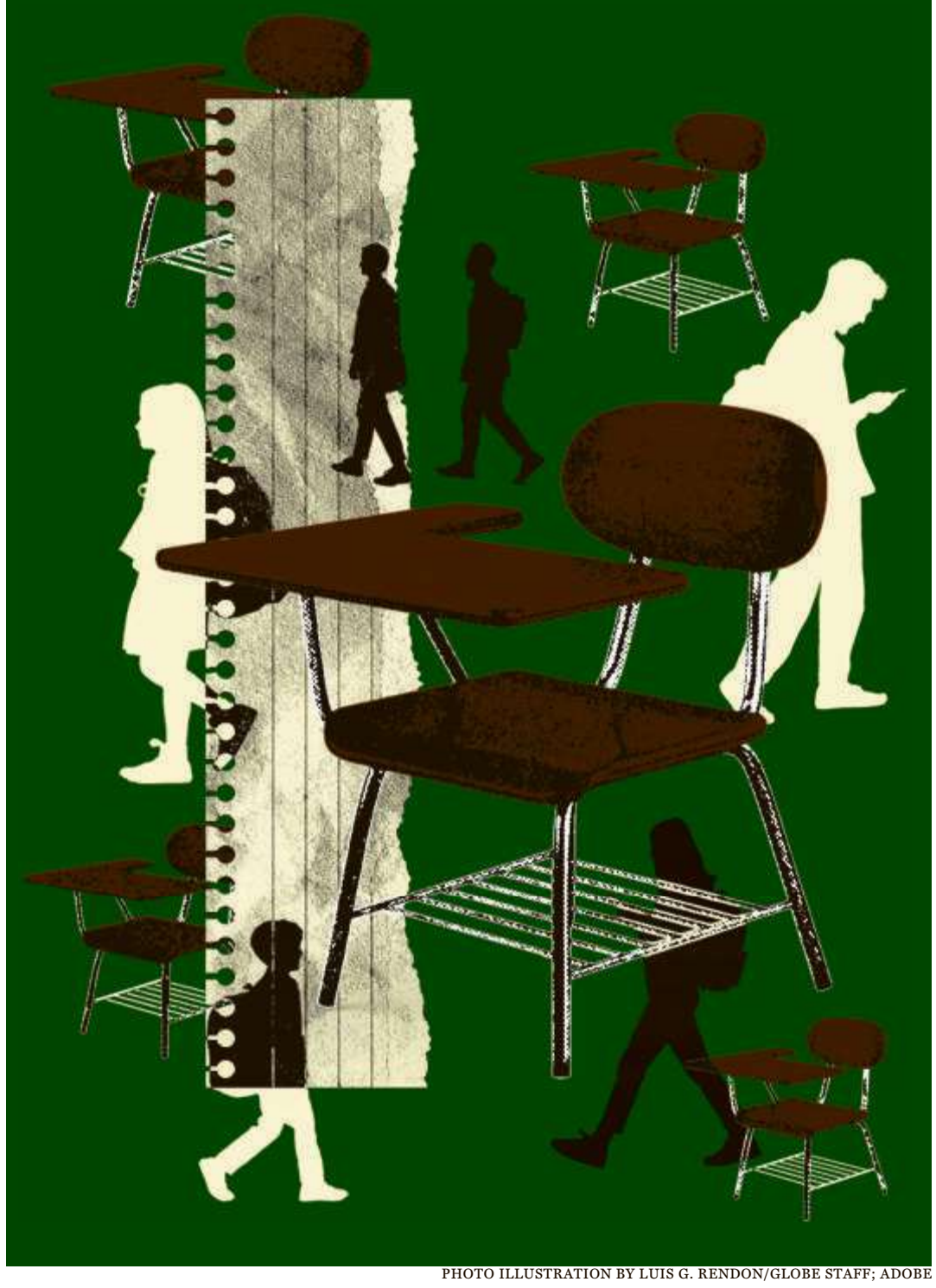


PHOTO ILLUSTRATION BY LUIS G. RENDON/GLOBE STAFF; ADOBE

By Marcela Rodrigues and Christopher Huffaker | Globe Staff

First in a three-part series

The bell at Chelsea High School had already rung on Oct. 1, but nearly 30 teens still lounged inside a nearby Dunkin', sipping drinks and complaining about algebra.

They come to this Dunkin' so often the girls will turn tables into vanities, plugging in curling irons and passing around tubes of scented lotion. Some get to school late, but others never show up at all.

Kids have always skipped class, but this is signaling a much larger problem, here in Chelsea and just about everywhere else in Massachusetts. Since the pandemic, the number of students missing school has surged in a widespread trend that jeopardizes the education of a generation of young people.

In Massachusetts, more students across all demographics are ditching, from those in lower-income immigrant communities to those in wealthy suburbs, high achievers to chronic truants on the cusp of dropping out.

They're missing for all kinds of reasons. In Boston, a parent pulls a first-grader out of class to visit family in the Dominican Republic when plane tickets are cheaper. In Lowell, a freshman works 30 hours a week bagging groceries at Market Basket and struggles to keep up in school. A star soccer player in Wellesley misses dozens of classes for out-of-state competitions and clinics.

In just the first few weeks this school year, 62 percent of Chelsea students had already missed at least one day. Absences had also begun piling up in New Bedford (48 percent of students had missed a day), Milford (45 percent), Lenox (44 percent), Arlington (24 percent), and Needham (22 percent).

Absences in Lynn had already topped 19,000 in kindergarten through high school — 19,000 missed days of phonics, geometry, and the hallway banter that help young people mature.

Since the pandemic, missed days have ballooned by nearly a third. That means Massachusetts students have missed an extra 15 million days of school since 2020.

The ranks of the chronically absent — those who skip at least one

ABSENTEEISM, Page A16

17%
of Mass. students are chronically absent (before the pandemic this number was 13%)

87%
of superintendents believe the pandemic changed the ways students think of education

73%
of superintendents said more students skip school for mental health days

'Mr. Veto' threat looms over Congress

Democrats prepare their legislative agenda as Trump sends mixed messages

By Jim Puzzanghera and Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Buckle up, America, for "President Trump vs. Congressional Democrats: The Sequel."

Tuesday's midterms deluge that swept Republicans out of power in Congress creates another political physics experiment starting Jan. 3: What happens when an irresistible force (Democrats riding a blue wave of voter discontent to large House and Senate majorities) meets an immovable object (a president loath to acknowledge any sign of weakness)?

►For Stephen Miller, midterm defeat is no reason to back down. A11.

After the 2018 midterms in Trump's first term, he and the House Democratic majority, led by Speaker Nancy Pelosi, clashed sharply and repeatedly, including two government shutdowns and an impeachment. But both sides also worked together to pass a revised trade deal with Canada and Mexico as well as enact two rounds of pandemic relief.

Next year, the dynamics will be different.

Democrats will have control of the Senate as well as the House, and Trump will be a lame duck coming off one of the most devastating midterm election rebukes in history.

Incoming Democratic leaders said they plan to follow through on their campaign promises to pass bills to reduce the cost of health care by restoring

DIVISION, Page A12

GRONK IN HIS GLORY



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Rob Gronkowski celebrated as he was inducted into the Patriots Hall of Fame Saturday in Foxborough. **C4.**

Celebrate the winter holidays with song, dance, theater, and more. Holiday Arts Guide, **N1.**

The Croft School had three campuses in peril. Just one survived. **Globe Magazine.**

Women's ice hockey is missing from the state's flagship universities. **C1.**

Without leaves

Sunday: Showers early. High: 57-62. Low: 45-50.

Monday: Partly sunny. High: 57-62. Low: 42-47.

Complete report, **A24.**

Deaths, A18-23.

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